

disturbed relative, just outside their front door. Her mother, a young widow, refused the custom of marrying her husband's brother. She battled cancer single-handedly. Through it all, she raised a firebrand daughter, who refused to back down.

Her cousins, who grew up near her home, were the more famous girls of the family. Geeta and Babita were among the first to win gold at the Commonwealth Games. They had a movie made about them, which made the 'Phogat sisters' iconic in Indian sports.

Vinesh didn't feature in that movie. The events described in it took place too early in her career. But

she wouldn't be satisfied with being one of the Phogat sisters — she would become 'The Phogat' sister.

Talk to any of her peers — and even some of her rivals in Indian wrestling — and there is, in some cases, grudging, genuine respect. She is considered the most instinctive and natural wrestler India has ever produced in women's freestyle wrestling.

Her career is as much a highlight reel as anything out of a movie. No one in women's wrestling compares. No Indian woman wrestler has won three Commonwealth gold medals as she did in 2014, 2018, and 2022. No one has won an Asian Games gold medal as she did in 2018. No

one has won two World Championships medals as she did in 2019 and 2022.

The one medal missing from her collection is the Olympic medal — which she fought bitterly for.

Vinesh has had terrible luck at the Olympics — the only competition that seems to matter to Indians. In 2016, she was one of the favourites in the Indian team before her knee was bent out of shape in the quarterfinals. In 2020, she was one of the world's favourites to medal in the women's 53kg weight class. Then, suddenly, a freak weight cut left her physically and psychologically broken, unable to coordinate her movements on the mat. She lost to a

PERHAPS THE MOST SIGNIFICANT FIGHT VINESH HAS FOUGHT HAS BEEN FOR THE SAFETY OF YOUNG GIRLS IN THE SPORT. IN PURSUING THIS FIGHT, SHE TOOK ON ONE OF THE MOST POWERFUL MEN IN INDIAN SPORTS - BRIJ BHUSHAN SHARAN SINGH

REUTERS

